

Testimony of Maureen Grosheider (Allegheny Regional Hearing)

Thank you for the opportunity to provide testimony to the House State Government Committee on the issue of Congressional Redistricting. This is an important and significant issue that will affect all Pennsylvanians.

My name is Maureen Grosheider. I am a resident of Allegheny County and reside in Marshall Township in the northwest corner of the county. My background is in financial services, primarily benefit plans and I have an MBA from the University of Pittsburgh. I served as a local Republican committeewoman for a number of years and I have been a volunteer with Fair Districts PA and with the Greater Pittsburgh League of Women Voters as well as having served on my local school board as an elected School Board Director for 20 years. Serving as a School Director in a district that was represented by more than one State House member provided me with one of my earliest lessons about the importance of drawing fair maps that help to create and support good government.

I have strong beliefs about redistricting in general, believing that districts should be compact, contiguous, as close in population as practicable and share common interests so as to allow citizens in those districts to receive appropriate representation from their elected officials. Districts should not be packed, cracked or designed simply to protect incumbents.

First, some comments about the process of drawing Congressional districts. The fact that we are having this hearing is evidence that you believe it's important to hear from constituents about their concerns and issues. I know that the Senate State Government Committee has also committed to doing hearings. From my perspective, it would have made far more sense for the two Committees to schedule hearings together rather than separately. Since both committees ultimately have to agree on a map, why ask citizens to say the same thing twice to two different groups? In addition, information about time and location of these hearings has been contained on the House GOP website rather than a nonpartisan website making it more difficult for citizens to find. These facts don't help to provide confidence in the transparency and impartiality of the redistricting process, which is so crucial to restoring the confidence of Pennsylvania voters.

I am unaware of why this particular location was chosen for the hearing, but it is a difficult location for many to access requiring either a car, or a long bus ride and then a fairly significant walk. Given that this is to be the only Allegheny County hearing, a more central location would have been a better choice. In addition, it would have been helpful had an option for virtual testimony had been provided to citizens. As you move forward with your hearing schedule, I suggest that you consider those issues.

At the time of the last redistricting, Allegheny County's population was 1,223,348 and based on total census data, each Congressional district was to contain around 710,000 people. Clearly, our county population called for more than one Congressional District, but not the three (12, 14, 18) that we got. The three districts in 2011 were not designed to serve the interests of the citizens but rather to serve political interests. Results like that should not happen again during this round of redistricting.

I reside in what is currently the 17th Congressional District, which covers a significant portion of Allegheny County and all of Beaver County. That is due to the state Supreme Court ruling on the redrawing of the PA Congressional map in 2018. The 17th District replaced my old District (the 12th), which had been drawn in 2011 after the last census. The 12th District snaked from Johnstown, PA all the way to the Ohio border and included parts of Cambria, Somerset, Westmoreland, Allegheny, Beaver, and Lawrence counties.

While you can say that that District was contiguous, it was just barely so since a sliver of Congressional District 14 jutted into it. The old District 12 made no sense from a geographic perspective nor did it reflect common interests or concerns by its constituents. The concerns of the voters in the Allegheny County portion of the 12th District truly did not mesh with the concerns of the voters in Johnstown in Cambria County.

In one example of the egregious gerrymandering of the 2011 map, two small boroughs on the northeast side of the Ohio River (Leetsdale and Edgeworth) were moved from their former home in District 12 into Congressional District 18 on the southwest side of the river despite sharing a common school district and community events with neighboring municipalities, also on the northeast side of the river.

This was done for political purposes, not to provide good governance. In that same 2011 map, the 3 Allegheny County Congressional Districts were drawn in such a way that in some locations, neighborhoods and even streets were split between the 18th and the 12th and 14th. Results like that should never occur in a fair and impartial process and I urge you not to replicate those kinds of maps.

Allegheny County's population based on the latest census data is 1,250,578, an increase from 2010, albeit small. Based on the PA population, each Congressional District will comprise around 765,000 residents. While the county is not large enough to qualify for only one Congressional District, it should not be split more than 2 ways. A split larger than that would mean diluting citizen input.

Drawing redistricting maps often means balancing competing interests against one another – very much like the art of compromising in the legislative process. It can be difficult, but with the technical tools that are now available, it is not an insurmountable challenge.

As you move forward in this process, I urge you to consider the following:

- The natural geographic boundaries of areas – how you get from here to there matters
- Municipal and school district borders
- Methods for providing the public with easier accessibility to information about the process
- A commitment to providing the public with sufficient time to review maps under consideration and to provide input prior to a vote on the maps being scheduled
- Providing a detailed explanation of the reasons and justification for whatever map is finally developed

Pennsylvanians need to believe that our legislators hear what we are saying and are acting in good faith. Please help to restore our confidence by acting in a transparent and accountable manner and producing maps that are nonpartisan and unbiased.

Thank you for allowing me to participate in this process.